ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



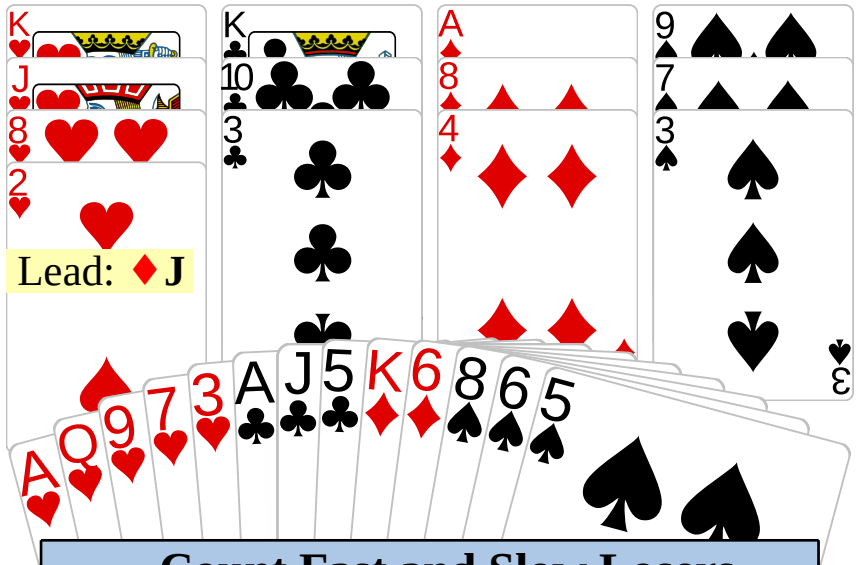
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



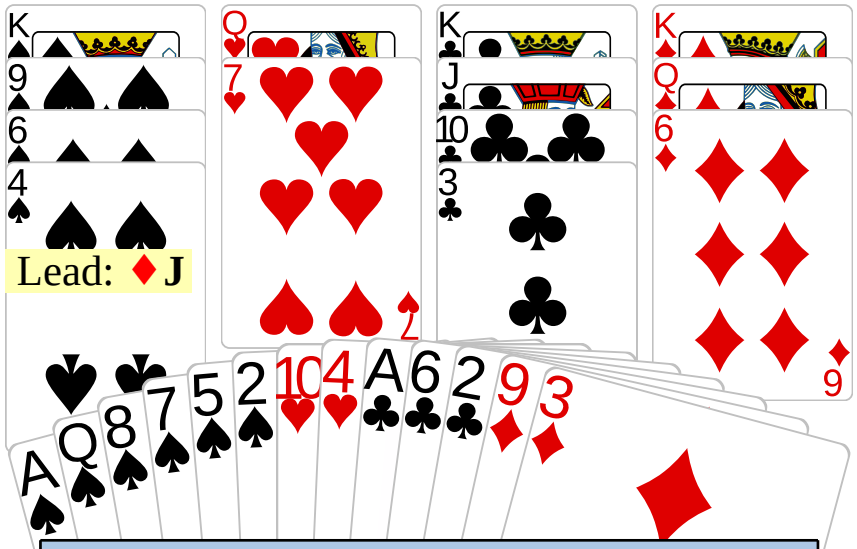
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



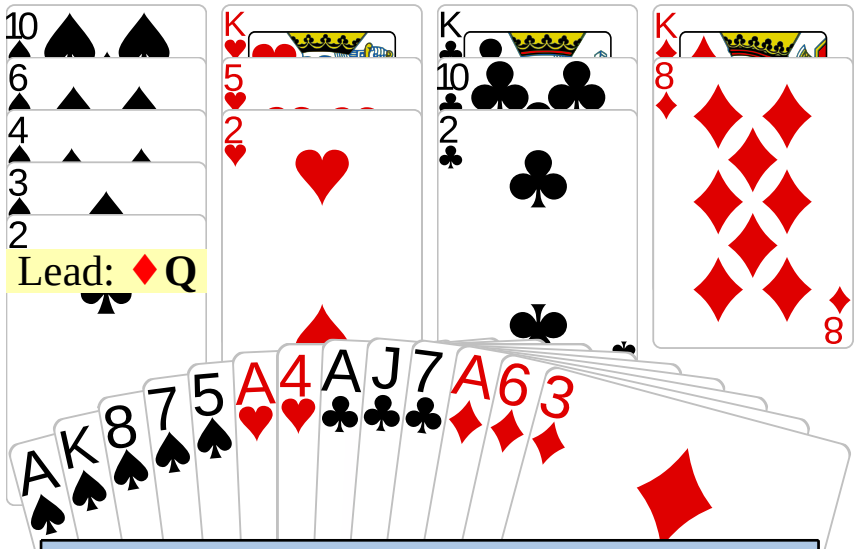
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 6 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦J

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦J

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 10 8 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ A J 7 ♣ A Q 5	
♠ Q 2 ♥ K 9 5 2 ♦ Q 8 5 4 ♣ 10 6 4	N W E S	♠ 5 ♥ Q J 10 8 7 ♦ 9 6 2 ♣ J 9 7 3
	♠ K 9 7 6 4 ♥ 6 4 ♦ K 10 3 ♣ K 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

South's 3♠ bid is a limit raise showing 10-12 points and good trump support. North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥Q.

This ♦ holding is the first example shown in the introduction.

With one certain ♥ loser you cannot afford to lose a ♦ also. You could guess which way to finesse and be correct half of the time. But an elimination play will work ALL of the time.

Win the first trick and play ♠A, ♠K. Trumps split 2-1.

Next play three rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit from both your and dummy's hand.

With all the eliminations completed you are in your hand.

The throw-in: a ♥ from either hand. One of the defenders wins (you don't care which), and is end-played.

The defender who won the last trick cannot lead a trump because he has none. If he leads a ♥ or a ♣ you will get a ruff-sluff, ruffing in one hand while discarding a ♦ loser from the other. If he leads a ♦ you will get the free finesse you were hoping for all along.

If you finesse West for the ♦Q you make the contract, but if you finesse East for that card you go down.

With an elimination play you make it no matter who holds the Queen.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 5 ♥ K 9 8 5 2 ♦ A 10 8 ♣ 10 9 6 3	
♠ K 9 7 6 4 ♥ 6 4 ♦ J 7 3 ♣ Q 8 2	N W E S	♠ A J 10 8 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ Q 5 2 ♣ A K 5
	♠ Q 2 ♥ Q J 10 7 ♦ K 9 6 4 ♣ J 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥Q

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♥Q.

This ♦ holding is the second example shown in the introduction.

This should remind you a lot of Deal 1. This time you have 1 ♥ loser and 3 ♦ losers. If you can force the opponents to lead ♦s you can make a trick with the ♦Q or ♦J, avoiding one of those losers.

Win the first trick and play ♠A, ♠K. Trumps split 2-1.

Next play three rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit from you and dummy.

The eliminations are complete and you are in your hand.

It is time for the throw-in: the small ♥, taken by one of the defenders.

No matter which defender wins the ♥ he is end-played. A ♥ or a ♣ will give you a ruff-sluff, but if he leads a ♦ you cannot be prevented from establishing either your ♦Q or ♦J as a winner.

If you try to make a ♦ trick on your own you will fail. The first defender will play "second-hand-low" and the other defender will take your ♦Q (or ♦J).

Only by forcing them to start the ♦s can you take a trick in the suit.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 9 7 6 4 ♥ 6 4 ♦ K 10 3 ♣ K 8 2	
♠ Q 2 ♥ Q J 10 7 ♦ Q 8 6 4 ♣ J 7 4	N W E S	♠ 5 ♥ K 9 8 5 2 ♦ J 5 2 ♣ 10 9 6 3
	♠ A J 10 8 3 ♥ A 3 ♦ A 9 7 ♣ A Q 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥Q

South is to play 6♠. West leads the ♥Q.

This ♦ holding is the third example shown in the introduction.

This is another follow-up to Deal 1. But this time you are missing both the ♦Q and ♦J. In this case an Elimination play doesn't give you a guarantee, it just improves your odds.

Win the first trick and play ♠A, ♠K. Trumps split 2-1.

Play three rounds of ♣s to eliminate the suit from you and dummy.

You are in your hand.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♥.

The defender who gets thrown in cannot play a ♥ or a ♣ without handing you the contract by way of a ruff-and-sluff. So he must lead a ♦. Suppose it is West who leads the ♦. You play low in dummy and East must play either the ♦Q or ♦J to keep you from getting a cheap trick with your ♦9. So you take East's honor with your ♦A and then finesse West for the other honor. As long as the ♦Q and ♦J are in different hands the elimination play will succeed.

Against good defenders there is no way you can make all three ♦ tricks if you make the first play in the suit. This assumes that if one defender held both the ♦Q and ♦J he would "split" the honors if you tried to lead through them.

By forcing them to start the ♦s you make three tricks when the two outstanding honors are divided.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K J 4 ♥ 10 5 ♦ J 10 9 3 2 ♣ Q 7 4	
♠ 8 6 5 ♥ A Q 9 7 3 ♦ K 6 ♣ A J 5		♠ 9 7 3 ♥ K J 8 2 ♦ A 8 4 ♣ K 10 3
	♠ A Q 10 2 ♥ 6 4 ♦ Q 7 5 ♣ 9 8 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦J

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♦J.

With three unavoidable ♠ losers you cannot afford to lose a ♣. So you either have to guess the location of the♣Q or (DRUMROLL) pull off an elimination play! Win the ♦K, then pull trumps, it takes two rounds.

Next you eliminate the ♦s by playing ♦A then ruffing the ♦8.

You execute the throw-in by leading a ♠.

The defense is in with a ♠ and they are welcome to take two more ♠s. But then they will to have to play a ♠ or a ♦, giving you a ruff-sluff, or else lead a ♣ which finds the ♣Q for you.

Using elimination plays makes you a better player. But in Bridge, no matter how skillful you are, there will always be a luck factor.

Here you were lucky the defense didn't start by taking their three ♠s. If they had, you would not have been able to pull off the throw-in, and would have had to try your luck with guessing who had the ♣Q.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 8 7 5 2 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 9 3 ♣ A 6 2	
♠ 10 ♥ K J 8 3 2 ♦ A 5 4 2 ♣ 9 7 4	N W E S	♠ J 3 ♥ A 9 6 5 ♦ J 10 8 7 ♣ Q 8 5
	♠ K 9 6 4 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K Q 6 ♣ K J 10 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦J

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♦J, covered by the ♦Q and ♦A. West returns a ♦ to the ♦K.

You still have two losers in the ♥ suit, so the question is which way you plan to finesse the ♣s. And of course the answer is that you don't plan to finesse them at all!

Pull trumps with the ♠A, then ♠K. Next ruff dummy's last ♦.

You exit with a ♥. The defenders win this and take another ♥ trick, leaving this position.

They must now break the ♣ suit for you or give you a ruff-sluff. Of course you would ruff in dummy and discard a ♣ from the 3-card holding in your hand.

If West is the one who has to play a ♣ you just let it ride around to dummy's ♣ K J 10 3.

If East is the one who has to play a ♣ you need to insert the ♣10 or ♣J from dummy.

In either case you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q J 9 ♥ Q 10 7 6 ♦ 10 5 2 ♣ 9 6 4	
♠ 10 6 4 3 2 ♥ K 5 2 ♦ K 8 ♣ K 10 2	N W E S	♠ A K 8 7 5 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ A J 7
	♠ — ♥ J 9 8 3 ♦ Q J 9 7 4 ♣ Q 8 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♠	Pass
3♠	Pass	6♠	
All Pass			

6♠ by East
Lead: ♦Q

West decides a limit raise is better than just jumping to game. East has heard enough and bids the slam.

East is to play 6♠. South leads the ♦Q.

Your first thought is probably that if you can guess the ♣Q you will make all thirteen tricks.

So you win the ♦K and play a ♠ to your ♠K. When South discards a ♦ your second thought is probably that you **MUST** guess the ♣Q just to make twelve tricks.

Hopefully your third thought is that if you use an elimination play you won't have to guess.

Play your ♠A, leaving North with the master ♠Q. Then eliminate ♦s by playing ♦A and ruffing a ♦ in dummy.

Now eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A, ♥K, and ruffing a ♥.

You are ready for the throw-in.

A ♠ to North's ♠Q.

North has just taken the defender's first trick. First and only. Because if he now plays a red card you will ruff in one hand and discard a losing ♣ from the other. And if he plays a ♣ you will no longer have a ♣ loser.

Most elimination plays work on the same principle. The biggest difference is usually the technique you have to use to complete the eliminations.

Here it took two ruffs, one in each hand.